not negotiate on the individual security interests of NATO allies: ‘Any initiatives in this respect, it seems to me, should come from Europe.’ He then asked for Macmillan’s views, emphasising again, ‘we must secure the actual dismantling of the missiles currently in Cuba as the first order of business.’ Macmillan’s reaction was to craft a proposal that would link immobilisation of the Thor IRBMs with the immobilisation of the missiles in Cuba. One purpose of this would be to make it easier for the Turks to accept any linkage. Kennedy demurred, not wanting too many dismantlings. He was, nevertheless, keen for NATO to take an initiative. Ideally, he would have liked the Turks to solve his problem by taking the initiative themselves.

Kennedy was well aware that world opinion could not comprehend why the Soviets could not deploy missiles in Cuba if the United States could deploy missiles in Turkey: ‘to any man at the United Nations or any other rational man, it will look like a very fair trade.’[52] As for NATO allies, ‘they don’t realise that in two or three days we may have a military strike, which could bring perhaps the seizure of Berlin or a strike on Turkey … and then they’ll say “By God! We should have taken it.”’[53]

So, how did Kennedy square the circle of maintaining alliance cohesion and finding a diplomatic settlement? The Presidential Recordings do not provide an answer to this question. However, in 1988 McGeorge Bundy published an account of what happened after the meeting of ExComm, at 7.45pm, when the President invited a small group of officials into the Oval Office. [54] Irritatingly for historians, JFK did not turn on his recording devices. Bundy’s account remains the principal source for what happened. He recalls that the meeting comprised the President and himself, Dean Rusk, Robert McNamara, Robert Kennedy, George Ball, Roswell Gilpatric, Tommy Thompson, and Ted Sorensen.

None of the ‘hawks’ were present, including the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs, Maxwell Taylor (or of course the other joint chiefs). Nor was DCI McCone, despite his willingness to trade the Turkish IRBMs. He did not have an especially warm relationship with the President, which presumably explains his absence. Vice President Johnson, who had played a limited role